



THE LEADER'S TABLE

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THE LEADERSHIP PLAYBOOK

10 Frameworks Every New Leader Needs

Proven models to lead with clarity, confidence & impact

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01

Situational Leadership

Paul Hersey & Ken Blanchard, 1969

WHAT IT IS **ADAPT YOUR STYLE TO WHERE YOUR PEOPLE ARE**

Hersey and Blanchard's Situational Leadership model holds that no single leadership style fits every situation. Effective leaders diagnose each team member's development level — their combination of competence and commitment — and then flex their style between Directing, Coaching, Supporting, and Delegating.

WHEN TO USE IT

When onboarding new hires, managing a mixed-experience team, or when someone who was once high-performing has become disengaged. Any time you notice a mismatch between someone's ability and their motivation.

TRY THIS TODAY

Pick one direct report. Rate their current competence (1-10) and commitment (1-10) on their main responsibility. If competence is low but commitment high, shift toward Directing. If both are high, move to Delegating. Adjust this week's check-in accordingly.

02

The RACI Matrix

Project management methodology, widely adopted in the 1980s

WHAT IT IS **END CONFUSION ABOUT WHO OWNS WHAT**

RACI is a responsibility assignment chart that maps every key task or decision to four roles: Responsible (does the work), Accountable (owns the outcome), Consulted (provides input), and Informed (kept in the loop). Only one person should ever be Accountable for any single task.

WHEN TO USE IT

When launching a new project, when work is falling through the cracks, or when team members are unclear about decision authority. Especially powerful in cross-functional initiatives where multiple teams overlap.

TRY THIS TODAY

Take your team's top three ongoing projects and list the five most critical tasks per project. For each task, assign R, A, C, I to team members. Share the matrix in your next team meeting and ask: 'Does this reflect reality?' Fix any mismatches together.

03

OKRs — Objectives & Key Results

Andrew Grove (Intel), popularized by John Doerr at Google

WHAT IT IS **ALIGN YOUR TEAM AROUND WHAT MATTERS MOST**

OKRs connect ambitious goals (Objectives) to measurable outcomes (Key Results). An Objective is qualitative and inspiring — the 'what.' Key Results are quantitative and time-bound — the 'how we'll know we got there.' OKRs are typically set quarterly, with 60-70% attainment considered a success (meaning they should stretch, not be safe bets).

WHEN TO USE IT
When your team lacks direction, when effort feels disconnected from company strategy, or when you need everyone rowing in the same direction. OKRs are equally powerful for a five-person team as for a 5,000-person organisation.

TRY THIS TODAY

Write one team OKR for the next 90 days. Start with the Objective: 'We will [inspiring goal].' Then write two to three Key Results: 'Measured by [specific metric] reaching [target] by [date].' Share it with your team and ask them to rate how motivating it feels — 1 to 10.

04

Radical Candor

Kim Scott, 2017 — author and former Google & Apple executive

WHAT IT IS **CARE PERSONALLY. CHALLENGE DIRECTLY.**

Kim Scott's Radical Candor framework sits at the intersection of two axes: caring personally about your people and challenging them directly. Too much care without challenge produces Ruinous Empathy — kind but ultimately unhelpful. Challenge without care becomes Obnoxious Aggression. The goal is the upper-right quadrant: honest, caring feedback that helps people grow.

WHEN TO USE IT
Whenever you need to give feedback — which is constantly. Particularly useful when you've been avoiding a difficult conversation, when someone is underperforming and doesn't know it, or when you want to build a culture where feedback flows freely in all directions.

TRY THIS TODAY

Think of a piece of feedback you've been holding back from someone on your team. Before your next 1:1, write one sentence that leads with genuine care ('I'm sharing this because I think you're capable of so much more') followed by the specific, direct observation. Deliver it this week.

05

The Eisenhower Matrix

Dwight D. Eisenhower, adapted by Stephen Covey in *The 7 Habits*

WHAT IT IS

The matrix organises tasks across two dimensions — Urgent vs. Not Urgent and Important vs. Not Important — creating four quadrants. Q1 (Urgent + Important): Do now. Q2 (Not Urgent + Important): Schedule. Q3 (Urgent + Not Important): Delegate. Q4 (Not Urgent + Not Important): Eliminate. Most leaders live in Q1 and Q3; great leaders protect Q2, where strategy lives.

STOP BEING BUSY. START BEING PRODUCTIVE.

WHEN TO USE IT

When you feel overwhelmed, reactive, or like you're always fighting fires. Use it in weekly planning, when your task list is unmanageable, or to coach a team member who is struggling with prioritisation.

TRY THIS TODAY

At the start of tomorrow, list everything on your plate. Map each item to one of the four quadrants. Count how many items land in Q2 (strategic, proactive work). If it's fewer than three, block 90 minutes this week specifically for Q2 work — and protect it like a board meeting.

06

Servant Leadership

Robert K. Greenleaf, 1970 — *'The Servant as Leader'*

WHAT IT IS

Greenleaf proposed that the most effective leaders start with the desire to serve first — and that leadership is then chosen as the means to serve most effectively. Servant leaders prioritise the growth and wellbeing of their people, remove obstacles, share power, and measure success by whether those they serve are growing, becoming healthier, wiser, freer, and more capable.

LEAD BY LIFTING OTHERS UP

WHEN TO USE IT

When building long-term team culture, when trust is low, or when you're taking over a team that has been micromanaged. Also powerful for leaders who want to create genuinely high-retention environments.

TRY THIS TODAY

In your next team meeting, open with one question: 'What's the single biggest obstacle slowing you down right now?' Listen without defending. Take notes. Then spend the next 48 hours removing at least one of those obstacles. Report back to the team what you did.

07

The GROW Model

Sir John Whitmore, Graham Alexander & Alan Fine — 1980s

WHAT IT IS **COACH YOUR TEAM INSTEAD OF TELLING THEM**

GROW is a four-stage coaching conversation framework: Goal (what does the person want to achieve?), Reality (what is the current situation?), Options (what could they do?), and Will (what will they actually commit to?). It moves people from stuck to actionable in a single conversation by helping them generate their own solutions rather than being told what to do.

WHEN TO USE IT

In 1:1 conversations when a team member brings you a problem. Also powerful for performance conversations, career development discussions, and any time you want to build ownership rather than dependency.

TRY THIS TODAY

The next time someone comes to you with a problem, resist the urge to solve it immediately. Instead, ask four GROW questions: 'What outcome do you want? Where are things now? What options have you considered? What will you do and by when?' Watch their ownership shift.

08

Psychological Safety

Amy C. Edmondson, Harvard Business School — 1999

WHAT IT IS **CREATE THE CONDITIONS FOR PEOPLE TO SPEAK UP**

Edmondson's research showed that the highest-performing teams at Google and beyond shared one defining quality: members felt safe to take interpersonal risks — speaking up, disagreeing, admitting mistakes — without fear of humiliation or punishment. Psychological safety is not about being nice; it is about creating the conditions where honest, productive work becomes possible.

WHEN TO USE IT

When your team is quiet in meetings, when ideas only come from the same people, when errors get hidden rather than surfaced, or when you want to build an innovative culture where calculated risk-taking is encouraged.

TRY THIS TODAY

At your next team meeting, share a mistake you made recently — and what you learned from it. Then ask: 'What's something we're doing that we should probably stop but haven't talked about?' Model vulnerability first. The team will follow.

09

The Five Dysfunctions of a Team

Patrick Lencioni, 2002

WHAT IT IS **NAME WHAT'S REALLY HOLDING YOUR TEAM BACK**

Lencioni's model presents a pyramid of five team failures, each built on the one below: Absence of Trust (unwilling to be vulnerable), Fear of Conflict (artificial harmony over real debate), Lack of Commitment (ambiguity over buy-in), Avoidance of Accountability (low standards go unchallenged), and Inattention to Results (ego or status over collective outcomes). Fix the foundation and the rest improves.

WHEN TO USE IT

When diagnosing a team that is underperforming despite having capable people. When conflict is either absent (unhealthy) or unproductive (destructive). When accountability conversations aren't happening.

TRY THIS TODAY

Run a five-minute team health check: have each team member privately rate your team 1-5 on each dysfunction (Trust, Conflict, Commitment, Accountability, Results). Average the scores. Share the results together. Use the lowest score as the starting point for your next team development conversation.

10

Transformational Leadership

James MacGregor Burns (1978), developed by Bernard M. Bass

WHAT IT IS **INSPIRE PEOPLE TO BECOME MORE THAN THEY THOUGHT POSSIBLE**

Bass expanded Burns' work to describe a leadership approach built on four components — the Four I's: Idealised Influence (leading by example, earning trust), Inspirational Motivation (articulating a compelling vision), Intellectual Stimulation (challenging assumptions, encouraging innovation), and Individualised Consideration (coaching each person as a unique individual). Transformational leaders elevate both performance and purpose.

WHEN TO USE IT

During periods of change, when morale is low, when a team needs a new sense of purpose, or when you want to develop future leaders from within your ranks. Especially effective for long-term culture building.

TRY THIS TODAY

Write a one-paragraph 'leadership vision statement' for your team: where you're going, why it matters, and how it connects to something bigger than the daily work. Read it aloud in your next team meeting. Then ask each person: 'What part of this vision excites you most?' Listen. Connect their answers back to their work.



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